golden opportunity in his plight. He offered the Mongol as much water as he could drink in return for cancelling his debt. What could the merchant do but agree? ‘A cup of water,’ he said, ‘is . . . more valuable than the wealth of the whole world.’ Even so, Humayun was canny enough to summon three men to witness the deal before giving the merchant his drink.

The Mongol lost but a small fortune; others in the camp were less lucky. ‘Many of our people died,’ writes Jouher, ‘and all suffered exceedingly.’

As the Mughals entered the land of Maldeo, it looked as if they might be coming into a bit of luck. Gulbadan says the raja sent them armour and money, and a generous message: ‘You are welcome! I give you Bikaner.’ Jouher writes that Raja Maldeo only sent them fruit, though even this, given the camp’s wretched state, must have been welcome.

Hamida would have been pleased. In early July 1542, when Humayun entered the desert, Hamida was about six months pregnant. It is hard to imagine what her suffering must have been; endless marches under a blazing sky, the dust blowing in her eyes and her flask running dry. But clearly, the fifteen-year-old kept her spirit. ‘In that waterless and grainless [desert] where it was difficult to find any trace of corn,’ writes Abul Fazl, Hamida declared she wanted a pomegranate. As she made this seemingly impossible demand, a man arrived with a sack of barley for sale. He opened the bag to show off his grain – and who would believe it! A ‘large, juicy pomegranate’ fell out.

Is this the miracle Abul Fazl declares it to be, or is he extrapolating matters from Maldeo’s gift of fruit? At any rate, Hamida got her pomegranate, and Humayun looked like he might get a foot through the door of Hindustan. Soon, however, that hope was revealed to be no more than a desert mirage.

Various sources credit the unmasking of Maldeo to various men.[36] The most apt of these stories is Gulbadan’s. She recounts how her bibliophile brother’s former librarian, one Mulla Surkh, found employment with Raja Maldeo after the ‘downfall and desolation in Hind’. It was this librarian who sent urgent word of the raja’s treachery. ‘Beware, a thousand times beware of advancing,’ he wrote. ‘March at once from wherever you are, for Maldeo intends to make you prisoner.’ Sher Shah, it seems, had offered the raja Alwar and Nagor in exchange for Humayun in chains.[37]